

THE BIG BAZAAR

By putting cricketers up for auction like paintings, IPL has generated deals worth over \$1.7 billion. But the big question is if it can sustain the frenzy and build loyal fans.

ing out prices on players may have made a few squeamish but IPL is nothing if not an exercise in putting cricketers and clubs out on the market for open valuation. The auction too was as naked a celebration of acquisition and consumerism that Indian sport would ever witness. When M.S. Dhoni's bid rose beyond six figures, auctioneer Richard Madley said joyfully, "And we have a one million bid." The room burst into applause.

A total of \$41.92 million was netted from the auction, of which total \$14.62

AP PHOTOGAUTAM SINGH



■ By Sharda Ugra

Welcome to the future," Andrew Wildblood said and if you listened closely, you could hear the sound of creaking. That was Sir Don Bradman and other deceased venerables turning in their graves. Cricket may have long shed its pristine whiteness in every sense but the future that Wildblood, IMG senior vice-president, was referring to, was something a psychedelic shade of purple. With flashing lights. And heavy metal music.

The Indian Premier League (IPL), BCCI's latest commercial enterprise disguised as domestic T20 competition, has been hailed as revolutionary and dismissed as revolting. Called an idea that could change cricket forever and a monster that could completely cannibalise it. It has generated deals worth over \$1.7 billion (Rs 6,818 crore) and led to a great churning in the game. But for shock value and impact, nothing came close to putting international cricketers up for auction like paintings or old furniture or indeed cattle. And then, in the manner of all



STARRY BIDS: Zinta was swotting up on the difference between zooter and sliders; Bangalore team management at the auction (top, left)

auctions, selling them to the highest bidder. In this case the team owners of the eight city franchises who will compete in the first IPL beginning April 18.

Since discovering its own value, Indian cricket has courted money often to the exclusion of all else. The IPL auction was the logical extension of this love affair with the free market. The sight of a professional auctioneer call-

million or more than one third went to 25 Indians other than the five designated 'icons': Sachin Tendulkar, Sourav Ganguly, Rahul Dravid, Yuvraj Singh and Virender Sehwag. The average fee for an Indian IPL cricketer (excluding the icons) is \$585,000 (Rs 2.34 crore) for a maximum of 16 matches. It is much more than the highest retainer paid out to international cricketers